

Sedona City Council tells SPD and city staff to turn off Flock cameras 2 min read

By **Joseph K Giddens** - August 14, 2025



An automated license plate reader on State Route 89A west of Airport Road is one of 11 of a planned 12 erected in Sedona limits since the beginning on June. The cameras were not active and only one city staffer, Sedona Police Department Patrol Cmdr. Chris Dowell, had access. After a work session on Wednesday, Aug. 13, a majority of Sedona City Council – Councilwomen Melissa Dunn and Kathy Kinsella and Councilmen Brian Fultz and Derek J. Pfaff – directed staff and police to shut off the ALPRs cameras indefinitely. Christopher Fox Graham/Larson Newspapers

The Sedona Police Department's Automated License Plate Reader program with Flock Group, Inc. has been indefinitely shut off following a majority consensus of Sedona City Council members at a special meeting on Wednesday, Aug. 13, with about 50, sometimes clamorous, attendees in the audience.

The majority consensus was reached through Councilwomen Melissa Dunn and Kathy Kinsella and Councilmen Brian Fultz, Pete Furman and Derek J. Pfaff in support of direction to turn off the ALPRS, with only Mayor Scott Jablow leaning against the decision. Vice Mayor Holli Ploog was absent and out of the country.

The council additionally directed city staff to provide a timeline of past discussions by the city leading up to the installation of its current 11 Flock

cameras with an additional one awaiting installation, form a citizen work group and return with a pilot program proposal.

The Flock cameras “are not mass surveillance” was repeatedly stated by Flock Director of Public Affairs Trevor Chandler and SPD Patrol Cmdr. Chris Dowell, who was the only person in the department with access to the Sedona ALPRs prior to their shutdown.

“ALPR is not a mass surveillance tool; it is a focused, objective investigative asset governed by strict data retention policies and transparency protocols. It enhances public safety without compromising community privacy,” Dowell said. “Under Supreme Court precedent, you do not have a reasonable expectation of privacy in movement on public roadways. ... Privacy on roadways and civil liberties are valid concerns ... and that’s why we have the protocols in place. ... In fact, we went a step above ... in our policy Hot List entries cannot be made without a supervisor’s approval.”

“Hot lists” are license plates that have been flagged by law enforcement and are often associated with wanted persons or stolen vehicles. While those flagged plates have a narrow focus in order to record those vehicles an ALPR scans and records every single vehicle that passes through its field of vision. That data is then stored in the cloud and is typically held for 30 days.

“Mass surveillance is indiscriminate surveillance,” as defined by United Kingdom-based Privacy International. “Mass surveillance uses systems or technologies that collect, analyse, and/or generate data on indefinite or large numbers of people instead of limiting surveillance to individuals about which there is reasonable suspicion of wrongdoing. Under currently available forms of mass surveillance, governments [and companies] can capture virtually all aspects of our lives.”

“It can pick up unique [vehicle] features, you don’t necessarily have to have a license plate,” Dowell said. “I can just put in ‘silver, Ford Explorer with [a] bumper sticker in the back window,’ and it will search that instead of just needing a license plate.” have noted that while data like that can appear

innocuous, capturing details like bumper stickers can potentially record an individual's political beliefs.

The full story will be in the Wednesday, Aug. 20, issue.

Joseph K Giddens



Joseph K. Giddens grew up in southern Arizona and studied natural resources at the University of Arizona. He later joined the National Park Service in many different roles focusing on geoscience education throughout the West. Drawn to deep time and ancient landscapes he's worked at: Dinosaur National Monument, Petrified Forest National Park, Badlands National Park and Saguaro National Park among several other public land sites. Prior to joining Sedona Red Rock News, he worked for several Tucson outlets as well as the Williams-Grand Canyon News and the Navajo-Hopi Observer. He frequently is reading historic issues of the Tombstone Epitaph newspaper and daydreaming about rockhounding. Contact him at jgiddens@larsonnewspapers.com or (928) 282-7795 ext. 122.

